



THE ICONOCLAST

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Simple Talk by Anthony Simeone

Life is complex enough already. We don't need sensationalism in the media, written or otherwise, pushing aside simpler truths for more profitable half-truths. So I have taken it upon myself to weed through the media muck that is raked up by the ton every day, and then present it back to the reading public (what's left of those who actually read, that is) in a purified form. Take Ebonics, for example. I first heard about Ebonics, or Black English, about a year ago. The information came to me from the mouth of an intellectual friend, long before the mass media sunk its fangs into it. Since then the likes of Dan Rather have drained the life out of the subject, having replaced the reality within with the hot air of sensationalism. The media has made the subject of Ebonics into an "issue", or even worse, a "controversy". This has made dealing with the topic all the more treacherous (not that it had to be treacherous in the first place). Thus, the masses have come to see Ebonics as too cumbersome and delicate a subject to discuss. In other words, they have made it too complex. Indeed, this humble writer has seen some of the results of the poisoning of the subject. One person I mentioned Ebonics to took me aside and spoke to me in a nervous whisper. This person informed me that Ebonics is going to be the "secret language" the blacks will use to baffle the whites during the impending "race war". Can you say "The Media Blows Everything Out Of Proportion For The Sake Of Ratings And Is Making Americans Hyper-Paranoid"? Ideas like the one above are the result of rampant sensationalism. They serve to fuel already-existing prejudice and give affirmation to bias. I have heard several other outlandish theories about why the black population is pushing so strongly for the use of Ebonics to help teach Standard English in mostly black schools. The debate over the validity of such a decision is being inflamed by unnecessary sensationalism. Here is how I would present the facts, with a sprinkling of my humble opinion, in such a debate (sans sensationalism): Ebonics (Black English) is a dialect of English. IT IS NOT "BAD ENGLISH"!!! As all dialects, it is a perfectly natural evolution of the language. A specific group of people, bound by a common ethnic heritage and sharing a similar economy and geography, may over time develop a dialect that best serves their purposes within their community. The key phrase here is "within their community". A dialect is a wonderful way for a people to bring themselves together. They can add their own innovations to the mother language. This creates a new dialect that helps to preserve the cultural distinctiveness of the group and

creates closeness within the community. But when dealing with others outside of the community, the people in said group should return to the mother language, or the standard dialect. This is done for the sake of communication with other people, who should also have a firm grasp of the standard. Ebonics came into being among urban black communities, those mostly in the lower economic strata of the American monetary caste system (which will be the subject of a future critical essay, no doubt, with accent on the "critical" part). It is a perfectly acceptable way for those in the aforementioned social group to use in communication amongst themselves. But when dealing with the other people that call themselves Americans as well, the black population of our country must know the standard form of English as well. This is necessary to preserve the integrity of the American community as a whole. All of the different ethnic groups that make up our country must maintain a working knowledge of Standard English. Our ethnic diversity should continue to be America's strength, not our weakness. Ethnocentric variations of English are acceptable. But if Africans, Italians, Hispanics, Koreans, etcetera, continue to stubbornly insist upon ignoring their responsibility as Americans to properly speak the standard, then there will always be racial problems here. Recognizing the need for a standard that must be adhered to strictly could be the first step towards realizing that we are not just a bunch of people with origins in various countries, but diverse people actually living together as Americans, and thus greater than just the sum of our combined ethnicities. As for Ebonics in schools, I see it as an impediment to the equality that the black community has struggled for for so long. It will only serve to keep black children from mastering Standard English. They must have a firm understanding of the standard to compete in mainstream American society, which is still a white majority. But to reach a balance of status between blacks and whites, the urban black children need the tools to compete on the same level as white children. And one of these necessary tools is Standard English. To insist that they need to be taught the standard through Ebonics is to insult the intelligence of black children. They need to be taught the standard directly to succeed. I believe that English is a miracle of the language species. It is able to borrow words from almost any language. It is this very trait of English makes it, I feel, the perfect way to unite people of diverse cultures and languages.

Letter to the Editors:

Andrea, or should I say, uh, "sillygoatgirl",

Since "I look like a guy who might be interested in this kind of thing," I took the liberty of examining the copy of the "Iconoclast" you so gratefully handed to me during my busy attempt at demanding that the New Jersey Department of Corrections allow my client access to mental health services.

But anyway...the reality of humanity is that we have become so much better at producing and developing great "things"--the problem is that they are the SAME THINS. Better, more efficient ways to kill. Better, more efficient ways to conduct commerce. Better, more efficient ways to con the average citizen into believing that we work for THEM. In sum, Destruction, Profit, and Consolidation of Power-- the triangle of human existence. The lessons of history are its confirmation.

Fortunately, we have reached a point where the nature of war is so destructive that the parameters of modern warfare between two superpowers will be altered forever. Some argue that a major "world war" is no longer feasible. To quote Einstein, "If World War III is fought with atomic weapons, then World War IV will be fought with sticks and stones."

Makes sense, eh? One cycle of the triangle. But alas, we live in a time where we have such liberty to discuss these issues, and promote Mr. Gates to the rank of Secretary of Defense. But my main concern is a simple dialogue (in the natural socratic method of questions to lead to more questions) so this is where I begin...

1) What is "THE ICONOCLAST"? Is this simply a literature pamphlet, or a promotion for a much larger political ambition, i.e. is there a driving political philosophy behind your publication...a much larger political purpose for which we all should join and end the corporate oligarchy that is America today? (oh, this should not be answered with a question, but rather more definitively)

2) What is "America"? Who is an "American"? Is there one, common, American culture? Or are we simply little sub-groups competing for own voice, and in turn, our own little piece of the pie?

3) #2 should take more than enough time, so I'll stop there.

So give me the scoop on this publication, and maybe a little history of your involvement and motivation for participation. If your goal was to enhance my curiosity, the computer lab approach was definitely a sure way to achieve it.

I appreciate the time of reading my incoherent ramblings...

-Sean

Iconoclast Response: revised from the original.

In answer to your very complex questions (or very easy questions depending upon the outlook).

1)The Iconoclast is subversive, but we are not political. But being subversive, of course we have an agenda. My personal agenda is to make everyone think like me and run through forests naked singing German Oktoberfest songs. But i doubt that ideal will ever be realized. (i think matt really wants to inspire a new appreciation for toilets, my friend shawn surely wants to find more nudey pictures on the internet, and bruce...well, let's just leave bruce out of this.)

2)America (last i heard) is the home of the free and the brave. i still think we're all just yellow and oppressed by "big brother." I think the best way to answer this is in a future article...look for it under "escapist religion." It will be the proverbial "doozy."

--talk about incoherent ramblings...

Non-sequitors by Jonathan Faszczyk and Matthew W. Weatherbee

"I got to dog a fly"

"I got to scoop some sugar"

"It's food for fuel"

"Don't stuff the frog"

"I'm packin' napkin"

"Till hell dilutes"

"It happens to the best of us, especially those of us who are eunuchs"

"I'll make you an offer you can't understand"

"We thrive on falafel"

"spam"

"Don't be such a sour carbuncle"

"It's one and a half dozen of the other"

"What's your chicken man?"

"What's up duke?"

"It's not the size, it's how you cut it"

"Till death do us a favor"

"Wayne Quesidilla"

"Good things come in ostensibly quasi-packages"

"Celabacy comes to those who wait"

"Gotta dance with the one who brought you"

"dog-food"

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STEVE-THE HOT DOG MAN

Condemned by God to poverty.

Resident of Rutgers
and a trained professional.

Julie by Sara M. Larsen

beyond the slam of screen doors
come velvet rain
fog thick as heartache.

o terrible beauty
hung on blue afternoon
footless ghost on stone steps:
let weather be had-unmouthed.

let it lick december thigh Mondays
let it slip like a voice into faraway places
--all dresses unwound.

o terrible beauty
hung on blue weather
beyond this terrible afternoon
there lies a midnight
--emblazened!--

come velvet midnight rain
ruin all slick jackets and shoes
and show the tops of pubic hairs in
drunkenness, give sudden red births
to ready lips, until

dawn cracks open like to a fish.

Leave by Jennifer Heine

The trains rattle
The yellowness of this house
Carrying pieces of the mother
Somewhere from somewhere.
All the time,
Toward the circle overhead,
Planes cart peoples
Place from place
I want to go.
The difference that it made
Makes not that difference
In your symbolic soul.
The difference that is made
Leaves these wholes unsown.
It is a song that sings
From a distant unseen radio
Unmatched by any artist
Laid down with no ink
Thoughts and notes for no one,
When there was a difference
We forgot to think.
The leaves that lift
From a plane's ascent are wet
Just as those that trail a train
The feelings they inspire
Are dead, alone, insane.

Carrots by Bruce Kramer

Innocence
Hundreds living side by side
The falling shadow
Uprooted from their homes
put in bins like some sort of animal
whisked away
mother's tear for her "chosen" child

today is harvest day
today the holocaust begins

the doctor like man
(white smock and funny hat)
hot water cleaning first
doctor's little knife
skin flaying
cries for help all unheard
screaming bodies
boiling liquid
dead and steaming placed on slabs
cheers of children at the sight of the dead

today is the picnic day
today the holocaust continues

And Wandering by Tommy Wright Jr.

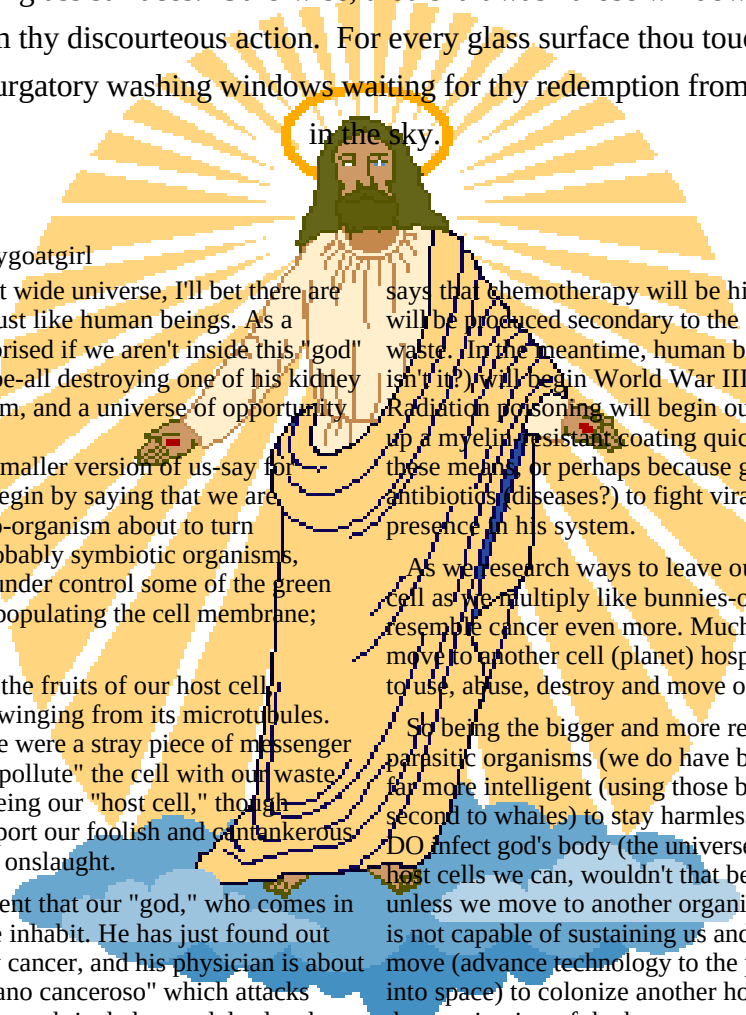
The subtle distancing of answers
that fortifies change
the painting of eden that hangs in your dreams
coming to life
while the unconscious road
between the pages of this guide
narrows into pieces
no longer fitting the frame
of a lonely child's reason.

Outside the window of these steps
seasons in reverse
that corner of brilliance in the world mouth
unable to linger
an advanced form of execution
what the mind sees the eye declines
opposite of what we would have thought
civilization in reverse
the story of a gate in disrepair
genius/madness
or was this area always
the resting place of god?

Time measured miles between your breaths
how much longer you asked
& there in the shifting of moments
a more complex strain of silence
when i was unable to brush away the dust
& openly weep
when i was unable to say
we were already there.

The Papal Decree of the Week:

When going through glass doorways, thou shalt use the handles provided instead of putting thy grubby mitts upon the freshly washen glass surfaces. Otherwise, thou shalt wash those windows by thyself and see the misery which ensues from thy discourteous action. For every glass surface thou toucheth, and smudgeh, thou shalt spend 100 years in purgatory washing windows waiting for thy redemption from the almighty glass cleaner



God's Cancer by sillygoatgirl

Somewhere out there in the great wide universe, I'll bet there are other useless parasites that act just like human beings. As a matter of fact, I wouldn't be surprised if we aren't inside this "god" we seem to think is the end-all-be-all destroying one of his kidney cells: space some big bloodstream, and a universe of opportunity to pillage neighboring cells.

If we compare ourselves to a smaller version of us-say for instance a benign cyst, we can begin by saying that we are presently a non-malignant micro-organism about to turn cancerous. Initially, we were probably symbiotic organisms, helping out the cell by keeping under control some of the green algae, and other organisms overpopulating the cell membrane; Perhaps we were just

non-malignant, benefiting from the fruits of our host cell, climbing its mitochondria and swinging from its microtubules. Never really harming the cell, we were a stray piece of messenger RNA. Now, we have begun to "pollute" the cell with our waste and biproducts, and the Earth, being our "host cell," though presently healthy enough to support our foolish and cantankerous ways can only survive a limited onslaught.

Now let us pretend for a moment that our "god," who comes in many forms, is the organism we inhabit. He has just found out that he has a rare form of kidney cancer, and his physician is about to treat him for a strain of "humano canceroso" which attacks healthy kidney cells and leaves them shriveled up and dead and spread slowly but fast enough to kill in a god-time. The doctor

says that chemotherapy will be his first attempt, and most of it will be produced secondary to the "humano canceroso" byproduct waste. In the meantime, human beings (ironic adjective there, isn't it?) will begin World War III with nuclear missiles. Radiation poisoning will begin our slow demise. If we don't build up a myelin resistant coating quickly enough, we will perish by these means, or perhaps because god is smart enough to take antibiotics (diseases?) to fight viral infections secondary to our presence in his system.

As we research ways to leave our cell (to go infest some other cell as we multiply like bunnies-or most parasitic organisms), we resemble cancer even more. Much like the aliens of ID4, we will move to another cell (planet) hospitable, with valuable resources to use, abuse, destroy and move on.

So being the bigger and more reasonable and thinking of the parasitic organisms (we do have brains you know), wouldn't it be far more intelligent (using those brains whose size are largest only second to whales) to stay harmless to our host cell? Because if we DO infect god's body (the universe) and destroy all the healthy host cells we can, wouldn't that be silly? We would surely die, unless we move to another organism, another god. And if this cell is not capable of sustaining us and we have failed to successfully move (advance technology to the point that we can rocket anyone into space) to colonize another host cell, then it will surely mean the termination of the human race. "Stupid senseless make it stop..."

What Possibility of Reconciliation. by Matthew W. Weatherbee

Fuck you, you dumb stupid fucking fuckhole. You get a fucking grip! You're an asshole for just thinking, something I rarely witness. You're a wittless renal virus; a genus not considered a sentient existence. Did we forget to mirror you shit stain. Thanks for the nagging bitch note. I can see your guts are

just past your ass and your skull is made of bone. Speaking of bones, you lard eating red, the next time you have one to pick, do it in person. Your eloquent message of tact, thought not of your capacity, truly bolsters the loving possibility of reconciliation.

Hell's Kitchen: a publication in Rochester, NY that the Iconoclast can be found printed among its pages.

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Untitled by Jen Oliver

My sister lit her cigarette with the car lighter while merging into traffic on 295. She did it well, a sure sign of hours of practice and addiction. "Uncle David's doctor said we should all check the bottoms of our feet, just to make sure we're in the clear." I've always felt weird calling him "uncle." He's my mother's youngest brother, but not much older than myself. Recently he discovered a growth on the bottom of his foot. It turned out to be malignant.

I sat in the passenger seat of her car, looking at my own feet, dressed up in hose and heels. If I had a growth there, I would know it. Wouldn't I?

I tried to conjure a mental image of the bottoms of my feet. Sometimes, in the summer, I put polish on my toenails and watched it chip away as the weeks of bare-feet and flip-flops went by. And if it's been a particularly bad day at work, in a new pair of shoes, I will rub my feet when I get home. But I never really took notice to their shape, their markings. I knew where I had other birthmarks (my left knee, at the upper curve of my mouth, on the tip of my nose.) But feet were different. They fell into that category of body parts that included the nape of the neck and the backs of ears. They were parts of my body, yet completely foreign and ignored. For the life of me, I could not remember what the bottoms of my feet looked like.

For a week, I walked around imagining an amorphous figure, like an amoeba from an 8th grade biology book, stuck on my foot. Moving and growing slowly, fat and black. I imagined I could scrub it off or burn it off the way my mother would get rid of a wart. But it would keep coming back like an invincible

tattoo.

Cancer is a legacy, like a horrible family seal. It never comes as a surprise, but it always comes as a sadness. The break of the news, "So and so has cancer" brings a collective sigh and a great feeling of affinity. It's like a group of people in the same war-time army bunker. There's life at stake.

I wanted to know, but I was afraid to look. Every moment I kept from looking at my feet was a moment I could believe there was nothing there to see. I silently cursed every prevention I never took. I wanted to re-live life with sunblock and apples instead of suntans and hamburgers.

Standing in line at the movie theater concession stand, I told my boyfriend, "I have to look at the bottom of my feet to make sure there aren't any abnormal markings. But I'm afraid to. Isn't that silly? I've been closing my eyes when I take my shoes off at night."

"Yes," he said, seeming more interested in how much butter was being poured onto his popcorn. "That's silly."

After the movie, back at home, I resolved that tonight would be the night I took a long hard look at my feet. We sat on the couch and started fighting over the remote. It turned into a playful wrestle, and Jon grabbed my leg by the ankle, and tore off my sock. When I realized what he was doing, I took a gasp of air. He examined my feet like a judge picking out the winning hen at a 4-H fair. Carefully, meticulously. He dropped my right leg, and picked up my left. "That one was ok," he said. I still didn't breathe. When he was done, he looked at me solemnly and said, "They smell. But that's about it."

TO: ETTY PINTO by Jonathan Faszczuk

It should be noted that the following essay is based on an enthusiastic and spontaneous incident in a stage of my life. I do not mean to proclaim any views on the state of Israel or its people. I still consider myself an Israeli "of sorts" and have great affection and compassionate ties for and to the country. So, again, please do not read more into this essay than appears on its surface. This particular letter or sentimentality and precious memory simply conveys my overwhelming love for ETTY PINTO at one point in my life. She has perhaps been my greatest love and hence stripped me of all sensibility and convictions at the time of my impressionable youth. Thank you.

Coming of the winged creature I'm still digesting the jubilation of the Hasidic Jews who are tired with wrinkles of anxiety outlining their gray and white feathered faces. Anxiety was my virtue and each moment irretrievable with felicity as the only proper word to address the occasion. The warm desert air made its

way onto the platform and a smile was well on its way to my soon to be parched face. My complexion always improves here. No need for a long decrepit horrid vestibule to assuage me onto my "final destination" (as it is often posted in "airport terminology" by "airport personnel"). I will take a bus and acclimate my body to the heat, the dirt, the palm trees and the beautiful landscape, which has been passive while its children practice their two handed backhand between Egypt, Mesopotamia, the Philistines, the Assyrians, the Greeks, the Romans, and the endless list which winds down to a microcosm of down and dirty greedy politics and ignoble, barbaric, and yet human mentality. God had no role on the road to Ashkelan; I looked for him in the baggage claim of the Ben Gurion airport. Zionism had drifted from my soul after having been exposed to the torn jeans of Bruce Springsteen the growling importance of a stable socioeconomic status, and the ever-so-gratifying American dream. I wasn't here to conquer or end my quest for identity. I was here to see my love.

"Amorous Peace" by Matthew W. Weatherbee

My Dearest, my pleasant Love
She Eclipses any world of enamoring idols.
Of beauty & song as strong as wine,
The senses entertained until sated, idle, satisfied in time.

But none that are painted, nor carved of stone
No shining star beheld alone, songs of Pan

And syc'more groves seen in dreams
Cannot inspire amorous peace.

When those affections born, beautiful in their own right,
Are too soon to take their flight; before expiring into emptiness,
Then—in tranquil calm, that amorous peace
I can love Her, love Her alone.

From the Pens of Bitch & Moan: Down With The Penis! or What Happened To Good Clean Metaphors?

by His Holiness the Reverend Doctor Minister Pope John Moan X

Welcome, welcome my children to another forum where we shall congregate and share our good clean thoughts. Where shall I begin? Damnation! That is where you shall find yourself if you travel down the sin infested path my counterpart is attempting to lead you down. When I was your age we did not have phallic references. Literature today is teeming with references to places of the body and acts of carnal sin that my pious mind cannot even begin to understand. Moby Dick? Terrible phallic name. Pool sticks, logs of cheese, firehoses, lighthouses! The Volvo company does not allude to a forbidden area of the female anatomy by accident my children! In fact, this whole publication reeks with the stench of sexual temptation and sin! Slappy Stink Monkey indeed! I am disgusted by such a creature. He is merely the devil's dirty little abomination. Was it not he who convinced Adam and Eve to eat the forbidden fruit? Goggle if you wish at the sight of the Washington Monument, drive into train tunnels, and drive past those oil storage tanks that look like the female busom (a device constructed by the oil people to lead you damnation! Subliminal messages in shapes like that.) I shall not be able to save you if you give in my children. (A donation to the church might perhaps might lessen your eternal torment however. But I go on a tangent here. Damn it, where was I?...)

Even that Rutherford B. Moan person who was gallivanting around here last month blathering on about the "stick of reason". The name itself stinks of hairy palms and blindness. I shall see him in the 10th Canto of Dante's Inferno before he knows what is good for him. Have you all no better way to express your opinion than through the disgusting vein of the genitalia? Nothing better to write about than snakes and poles and headlights and what they stand for? Such things drag literature and with it the mores of the world down to smut! Blasphemy I say! Thou shall not think of references to the woman's genitalia. Turn your head at the sight of the flesh with its curves. Its...smoothness. Its fullness. The...um, terribleness of such glorious inviting flesh! The temptation is overwhelming but do not give into the hedonistic calling of such pheromone reeking splendor. I shall pound my fist at such things. Stand at my rear my children! I shall beat away the serpent of such evil with my holy staff...and such a manly staff it is at that. So large and big and . . . oh my. It appears that I must venture down the holy path to the pearly gates of my bathroom to purge myself of these unpure thoughts with my copy of "Play Nun". I shall pray for you my children and remember "practice what you preach" or "do not practice what the preacher preaches" or something like that.

A Critically Positive Study of the Phallic Symbol or You've Got A Freud In Me

by Dr. Sigmund Wilhelm von Bitch, Ph.D.

Guten tag! Today, we will be studying the many manifestations of the phallic symbol. And I, Dr. Sigmund Wilhelm von Bitch, will be your guide through time and space, history, and the human mind itself. Let me begin by saying that Sigmund Freud (who I was named after, you know) was right! I will follow his factual statement by saying that the phallic symbol is ubiquitous in human history and culture. All across the world, evidence past and present can be found to support the omnipresence of our long and slender friend. In ancient Mesopotamia, for example, the phallic symbol inspired the cults that worshipped the hallucinogenic mushrooms that are plentiful in that place. Have you ever seen a mushroom? Ja? Well, what do they look like, huh? The mushroom gave proof that even nature itself loves the men's pee-pee! Zen on to ancient Egypt! What do you think gave them the idea for the obelisks? That's right! And in ancient Greece they made all kinds of naughty paintings on their pottery (of course, you won't see any of them in the prudish museums we have in the Western Civilization, ja?). Today, the phallic symbol is still with us. In

Japan, they still make giant pee-pees for everyone to hug on special days set aside for celebrations of fertility. And what do you think gave America's founding fathers the idea of the Washington Monument? Zen ask yourself why one of the symbols of America is the HOT DOG?! Have you ever seen a hot dog? Why does everyone like hot dogs, huh? Now you know why! Ja, this is just what I like to call a "tease eezay"! I will elaborate upon the phallic symbol in my next lecture entitled "The History of the Penis and the Male Masturbation Paradigm", or as I like to call it, "Goin' Blind and Loving It"! After that I will present my evidence supporting the hypothesis that Schlappy Shtink Monkee is the Missink Link! Don't miss it! And you more zing to keep in mind...BEWARE RELIGIOUS ZEALOTS! Especially you MOANING about how Satan wants you to play with yourself! He is a silly man who kneels in front of God too much, if you know what I mean! So until next time, remember...SCIENCE RUUUULEZZZ!



Missing Snowflake by Amy Popp

Three winters ago, on a snowy, icy, (very icy and snowy), Saturday, I felt a desperateneed to own a cat. This imminent feeling had been brewing for several weeks. My family had two cats that belonged to the four of us; I wanted a cat I could call my own, be devoted to and vice versa. Therefore, in the heat of my urge, I called a friend and asked if he would go to the SPCA with me. Mind you, I had to ask someone a little crazy like me, to trek out in the icy snow, travel on the subway, and walk a mile to the SPCA in North Philadelphia. My choice of friends was on target; he said he would love to go. He shared my thrill in this project. Neither he nor I minded that the weather had kept most indoors; I, especially, had a mission; I wanted a cat to cuddle and be my friend. Through the cages of the animal shelter I fell in love. Its fur was marmalade and snow colored, that blended together to create a perfect pastel softness. It was a boy; I had anticipated getting a girl, but I knew he would be just perfect. I held him and took in his sweet, quiet nature. I decided I would name him Snowflake. The name just seemed to come magically out of the snowiness of the day and the softness of my little friend. I think he liked me too; after all I did save his life, and I promised him that he would have a good home, and that I would take good care of him. I officially adopted my "little buddy", as I would refer to him in the future. He was so well behaved. The gentle nature of this little cat was astounding.

My friend and I tried to get a cab to the subway station, but after forty five minutes of waiting, we decided it would just be faster to start walking. Yes, we walked with Snowflake in his cardboard SPCA carrying case. Thankfully, I had brought a towel with me, so I put that at the bottom of his case. Unbelievably, my new little friend only meowed every fifteen minutes or so. Considering the conditions, this was amazing to me; it had started to snow again and the temperature must have been below freezing.

Snowflake's behavior was even better on the subway. My Snowflake was indeed a survivor and a city cat. He had endeared himself to me from the very beginning, and I knew he would be a comforting, joyful, little companion.

Snowflake turned out to be a perfect gentleman. Affectionate, devoted, and wee behaved. He was a good judge of character too; when someone he was afraid of came over, he hid or ran away. It always turned out he had used good judgement. Interestingly, Snowflake was very amicable to my boyfriend, which affirmed my faith in my boyfriend. Sometimes Snowflake would get jealous of the time I spent with him; at these times he would try to get my attention by knocking over his bowl of water or knocking over a can of pens or something breakable. This behavior was irritating to me, but in reflection, it touched me that my cat was attached to me.

There were times when I did neglect him. And he rebelled. Snowflake ran away for a month, a year after I got him. I was so busy I did not realize he was missing until about two days after he had left. I felt so terrible; I realized I hadn't been paying much attention to him; I felt horribly guilty. That was a very sad month for me. I put up signs in the neighborhood, called the SPCA, asked neighbors if they had seen him, in hopes that I could find. There were a few false leads, one particularly distressing. Neighborhood kids, in pursuit of the reward, called me and said

they had seen a few cats fitting Snowflake's description. Upon meeting them, they led me to one cat that was not Snowflake, and then pointed to another; it had been hit by a car and was at the side of the road. Thank goodness it wasn't Snowflake; it was really terrifying though.

After about three weeks I had convinced myself Snowflake must have found a better home, where people took better care of him. During those weeks I was very teary; it was quite sad to lose my little friend.

One fine day, upon opening the door, on my way upstairs, I saw a tan cat sitting, upright, under the dining room table. It was a dusty, thin kitty.; it was my lost Snowflake. As if out of a "reuniting" or "lost child" drama, I spilled tears with every, "Snowflake! My little baby!" I was a bit afraid to pet and hug him too much because he was so dirty and I didn't know where he had roamed in his travels. He seemed relieved to be back, purring, and purring, and purring. Perhaps he needed to travel a bit; after all, he was a teen in cat years.

After that emotional incident, I truly cherished Snowflake. I got him "Fancy Feast" for the first few weeks he was back and then as my budget allowed. I also got him a jazzy blue collar, with a name tag, so I wouldn't lose him again, and appreciated his company to the fullest.

Then there came a day two years ago when I had to say goodbye to my cat. I was moving into a small apartment. I could have brought Snowflake, but I knew he wouldn't have been happy. He had grown to love the outdoors and I thought the apartment would truly stifle him. It was a hard decision to make, but I did think it would be in Snowflake's best interests.

My friend and her husband were moving to West Virginia and were going to live on a farm. They happily accented to adopting Snowflake; "the more cats the better" was their sentiment. This would be paradise for my spirited cat. He could run around on the farm, keep company with five cats, horses, cows, and chickens, and would be well taken care of by my friends.

There are times when I really miss the little fellow though. Last fall, after studying for finals, I walked into my apartment and thought I saw Snowflake sitting on my bed. My tan teddy bear had triggered my psychedelic illusion. I assumed that studying for finals had frayed my nerves. It was certainly a jolt.

My friend sent me a picture of Snowflake lounging in the rafters of the barn. He loves the hay. I put the picture up on my refrigerator door; he looks very content.

So, every once in awhile, pangs of sentimentality hit me; I reminisce about his little "meow" when he needed food or attention, his gentle presence, and especially the feeling of him curling up next to me on my bed.

Nowadays, I give my teddy bears a lot of attention, for which I think they are very grateful. In fact, I have started a teddy bear collection. I guess I am trying fill the void my little Snowflake left.

Someday, I hope to visit my little buddy in West Virginia. I'm hoping that the tales I've heard, about cats never forgetting their owners, are true. Sometimes I wonder if he misses me; I worry that he isn't getting enough hugs down there. Oh well. I will always have his gentle paw print ingrained in my memory.



DAMN! by bertram redgrave

damn! from twenty feet away he could see the lock on his locker hanging open. a backward "s" that ridiculed the two superman comics that were inside. he knew he locked the lock before class; he had pushed the lock shut and turned the dial several times and tugged to be sure, and yet now it was open.

there are only two copies of the combination, one at home in his desk and the other behind the picture of susy in his billfold. both places were safe, no one would move susy's picture, plain and mousy; she had given him the photo and a kiss on his birthday. so someone, some scum, had stood there in the hallway and turned the dial, listened for the falling tumblers, while he was in class.

they would have taken the ten packs of gum he had put there that morning. criminals do that. then they stand in the hallway, leaning against the wall and chew the gum to ridicule their

classmates. pushing and swearing until it is time to dash for class. and they would have found his pocket protector, filled with pens, that his mother had given him to protect his shirt. the one he hid in his locker every day, so even if they called him a nerd, there was no proof. and the snapshot of joanie, the one at the pep rally, frozen in a leaping cheer, the big "a" of abercrombie high school wrapped across her chest. that would be gone, and the whole school laughed at his liking her. she only dated senior, but one day, he would save her from something, or she would ask for a pencil and their eyes would meet and...his life was in that locker; half of a milky-way, cliff notes, an unopened condom brittle with age.

....it was only when he reached for the handle that he realized that the locker with the open lock was not his.



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